User Test Report V1

Chartsmither — Full Product Sweep

Date: 2026-03-22 | Tester: Product Ensemble (User Tester Agent)

Executive Summary

6 simulated personas walked through Chartsmither's actual codebase, tracing every click, handler, and state flow. The product is **functional and well-architected** but has **4 critical issues** that would block or frustrate real users, plus **8 friction issues** that degrade the experience.

Verdict: Ship-ready for desktop users after P0 fixes. Mobile experience needs work before tablet/phone users are targeted.

```
                    PASS   PARTIAL   FAIL

                    ┌──┐   ┌──────┐  ┌──┐
First-Time Visitor  │▇▇│   │      │  │  │  ✓ Can make + download a chart
Non-Technical User  │▇▇│   │      │  │  │  ✓ Paste from Excel works great
Rushing Consultant  │  │   │▇▇▇▇▇▇│  │  │  ~ Theme fonts don't change
Power User          │  │   │▇▇▇▇▇▇│  │  │  ~ DPI ignored for PDF/PPTX
Report Builder      │  │   │▇▇▇▇▇▇│  │  │  ~ Gallery empty on first visit
Mobile User         │  │   │      │  │▇▇│  ✗ Report Builder layout breaks
                    └──┘   └──────┘  └──┘
```

Persona Results Matrix

Capability	First-Time Visitor	Rushing Consult.	Non-Tech	Power User	Report Builder
Find a chart	✓	~	✓	✓	n/a
Load sample data	✓	✓	✓	✓	n/a
Paste own data	✓	✓	✓	✓	n/a
Customize options	n/a	~	n/a	~	n/a
Switch themes	n/a	~	n/a	✓	n/a
Export PNG	✓	✓	✓	✓	n/a
Export PDF	n/a	✓	n/a	~	✓
Export PPTX	n/a	n/a	n/a	~	✓
Create report	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	✓
Add charts to report	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	~
Export report	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	✓
Mobile/tablet use	~	✗	~	✗	✗
Overall	PASS	PARTIAL	PASS	PARTIAL	PARTIAL

✓ = Works ~ = Works with friction ✗ = Broken n/a = Not tested

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Issue Severity Distribution

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CRITICAL ▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇  4 issues   ← Fix before next release
FRICTION ▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇  8 issues   ← Fix in next sprint
MISSING  ▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇  4 issues   ← Quality polish
         ──────────────────────────────────────
         0    2    4    6    8    10
```

```
By Fix Size:

  Small (S)  ▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇▇
```

CRIT-3: Chart gallery empty on first visit to Reports

Field	Detail
Personas	Report Builder
Severity	Critical — core Report Builder flow dead-ends
File	`src/pages/EditorPage.tsx:131–137`
Root cause	`saveToGallery` has 2-second debounce; if user navigates to Reports before it fires, gallery is empty
Expected	Charts appear in gallery immediately after creation
Actual	2s delay; fast navigation = empty gallery, confused user
Fix size	M — save to gallery on navigate-away or reduce debounce

CRIT-4: Theme switch only changes colors, not fonts

Field	Detail
Personas	Rushing Consultant
Severity	Critical — "McKinsey branding" promise not fully delivered
File	`src/components/data-input/OptionsPanel.tsx:344`
Root cause	Theme picker sets `brandTheme` and `colorOverrides` but font changes don't propagate to Chart.js renderers (hardcoded to ECONOMIST_FONTS)
Expected	FT theme uses Georgia serif; Bloomberg uses Arial Black
Actual	All themes use Helvetica Neue for chart text
Fix size	M — pipe theme fonts through buildBaseOptions and ChartWrapper

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Friction Issues (P1-P2)

Priority Matrix

```
             LOW EFFORT ←──────────────→ HIGH EFFORT
         ┌──────────────────────────────────────────┐
    HIGH │  #5 Delete confirm    │  #12 Mobile nav  │
 IMPACT  │  #6 Export validation │                  │
         │  #7 Paste in JSON mode│                  │
         │  #8 Export silent fail│                  │
         ├──────────────────────┼──────────────────┤
     LOW │  #9 Ref line limit   │                  │
 IMPACT  │  #10 Axis validation │                  │
         │  #11 LineWidth 0.6x  │                  │
         └──────────────────────────────────────────┘
```

```
Quick wins (top-left): 5 issues fixable in < 2 hours total
```

#	Issue	Persona	File	Fix
5	Report delete — no confirmation, uses `window.location.reload()`	Report Builder	`ReportsPage.tsx:82`	Add confirm dialog or undo toast
6	Can export report with empty title/client	Report Builder	`ReportsPage.tsx:225-242`	Warning before export if metadata empty
7	Paste event silently ignored in JSON tab	Non-Technical	`DataEditor.tsx:98`	Auto-switch to paste tab on paste detect
8	Export buttons silently fail if chartRef null	First-Timer	`ExportBar.tsx:61`	Disable buttons until chart rendered
9	Reference line 3-limit not communicated	Power User	`OptionsPanel.tsx:273`	Show "(max 3)" label
10	Y-axis min > max not validated	Power User	`OptionsPanel.tsx:559-577`	Swap or warn
11	StackedArea lineWidth has hidden 0.6x factor	Power User	`chartjs/index.tsx:396`	Remove multiplier
12	Nav bar doesn't collapse on mobile	Mobile	`AppShell.tsx:84-115`	Hamburger menu < 768px

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Missing States

#	State	When	Current Behavior	Expected	File
13	Report Builder loading	Click "New report"	Brief blank flash	Skeleton or spinner	`ReportsPage.tsx:196`
14	Theme change overwrites custom colors	Switch theme after manual color edits	Custom colors silently replaced	Warning before overwrite	`OptionsPanel.tsx:344`
15	Report with orphaned chart	Chart deleted from gallery	"Chart unavailable" placeholder	**Already handled** ✓	`ReportsPage.tsx:133`
16	Report deletion	Click trash icon	Immediate delete + page reload	Confirmation dialog	`ReportsPage.tsx:82`

Positive Findings

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WHAT WORKS WELL                          WHY IT MATTERS
──────────────────────────────────────   ──────────────────────────────────
Paste-first data input default           Non-tech users never see JSON
Smart CSV/TSV auto-detection             Paste from Excel "just works"
Sample data on every chart (49/49)       Zero empty-state anxiety
"Change sample data" cycling             Instant chart exploration
Theme-driven cover pages                 McKinsey cover looks like McKinsey
Chart editor auto-save                   No data loss on refresh
Reference lines + data labels            Publication-quality output
5-theme masthead recoloring              Instant brand switching
WYSIWYG report preview                   What you see is what you export
Orphaned chart handling in reports        Graceful degradation
```

Recommended Fix Sequence

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PHASE A — Ship Blockers (do now, ~3 hours)
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  [1] Report Builder responsive grid        S   30 min
  [2] PDF/PPTX DPI passthrough             S   15 min
  [3] Gallery save on navigate-away         M   45 min
  [4] Theme fonts in Chart.js renderers     M   90 min

PHASE B — Quick Wins (~1.5 hours)
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  [5] Report delete confirmation            S   15 min
  [6] Export metadata validation            S   15 min
  [7] Auto-switch to paste tab on paste     S   15 min
  [8] Disable export until chart ready      S   15 min
  [9] Reference line "(max 3)" label        S   5 min
  [10] Axis min/max swap validation         S   10 min
  [11] Remove StackedArea 0.6x factor       S   5 min

PHASE C — Mobile Polish (when targeting tablets)
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  [12] Mobile nav collapse                  M   60 min
  [13] Report Builder loading state         S   15 min
  [14] Theme change color overwrite warning S   20 min
```

Test Methodology

- **Agent:** Product Ensemble User Tester (v1.0)
- **Method:** Code trace — read actual source files, follow routes, verify handlers, check state flows
- **Codebase:** `/Users/milovandekic/chartsmither` at commit `1611eca`
- **Scope:** Full product sweep — all routes, all features
- **Personas:** 6 (First-Timer, Rushing Consultant, Non-Technical User, Power User, Report Builder, Mobile User)

- **Not tested:** Backend (none exists), authentication (none exists), real browser rendering (code trace only)

Generated by Product Ensemble User Tester | Chartsmither V1 | 2026-03-22